

ROUGH CUT | KAVEREE BAMZAI

Grrr Power

Randi bolna ab out of fashion *ho gaya hai*," says the young prostitute to the young boy brat in *Dev D*. I wish. Look around and coarse seems to have become cool. Abuse has become attitude especially for girls, long told to keep their heads down and their noses to the grind. Observe them, fashionably dressed, popping clingy cleavage and showing great gams, sitting in a panel on MTV's *Splitsville*'s Valentine's Day special uttering the vilest abuse at each other. Having competed last year for the affections of two unlovely boys, there they were now recalling their cat fights, with more catfights. Among the wonderfully taxing tasks they were given last year was uttering a string of 20 abuses and wrestling each other in mud. Wow. It's pretty much the routine on *MTV Roadies*, where boys and girls, mostly straight out of school, have to not only stay with each other for a long period of time, probably for the first time in their short lives but also kiss, claw and hiss for shock effect. The show encourages rudeness and gang-like warfare, and in one episode I was particularly struck by veejay Rannvijay dismissing the current group as spineless because they weren't nasty enough to each other. Another youth channel, Bindass, has a badass babe, in dominatrix gear, trotting out insulting obscenities on a show called *Dadagiri*. And yes, look at the way the pink chaddi campaign has been embraced by young women despite most of them knowing that Valentine's Day is an elaborate con pulled off on them by a combination of card manufacturers, candy makers and florists, plus desperate middle-aged men who were perhaps love-starved young boys.

Is this the future? Even as we strive to find the 18 million pieces that the glass ceiling has supposedly been shattered into

by Hillary Clinton, do we also not fight for the freedom to love, to lust, to hang loose? Yes, economic independence is worth nothing more than the paper of the paycheque if it is not accompanied by social liberty. The acceptance that women have that right has not come with them diligently doing their day jobs while also trying to make the breakfast in the morning and helping with the children's homework at night. Will it come now if they raise their voices not just in protest but in rage? Can the Muthaliks of the world be shamed by the sight of undies just as America was aghast at the sight of bra-burning women? Or will it enrage them more? At the India Today Woman summit in Mumbai last week, I saw a smart young woman quizzing Sheila Dikshit about the safety of women in Delhi. The elegant Mrs D did not have an answer except that women should try to be safe. That's not of much help. Whether or not you're wearing pink undies.



SIGNPOSTS

SENTENCED: Moninder Singh Pandher (below) and his domestic help Surinder Koli, to death by a special court for the rape and murder of



Rimpa Haldar, one of the 19 victims in the Nithari serial killings.

BANNED: By the Election Commission, the publication and telecast of **opinion and exit poll results** 48 hours before and after the first phase of the coming Lok Sabha polls.

DENIED: By the Delhi High Court, bail to Deputy Speaker of Manipur Legislative Assembly **Thounaojam Shyam Kumar Singh** for allegedly leaking strategic army and paramilitary forces' positions to banned terrorist outfits.

DIED: Gyan Patnaik, 90, wife of former Orissa chief minister late Biju Patnaik. She was one of India's first women pilots and had flown on several trips across the world.



SAURABH SINGH

